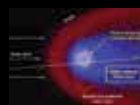




A complete guide to Pluto

New Horizons has given so much information about Pluto, Charon and more. Head here to know everything: <http://digit.in/1Jjah2d>



Pluto's losing it

According to NASA, it seems that Pluto's nitrogen atmosphere is escaping into space. <http://digit.in/1em4PP4>

New Horizons

My very efficient mother just served us nine...

Robert Sovereign-Smith

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Damn you Neil deGrasse Tyson, Mike Brown and the others who killed Pluto as a planet! The beloved Planetary Mnemonic (whichever one you learnt as a kid) will never be the same when we stop at Neptune!

Thankfully, NASA didn't really listen, and sent out a probe called 'New Horizons' towards Pluto. Planet or not, Pluto needed to be explored, and it's kind of fitting, given all that we've learnt over the past few weeks, that Pluto was left for last – we really did save the best for last.

OK, we're kidding. We don't really want Pluto to be made a planet again. We're just glad it's the first trans-Neptunian object seen at close range.

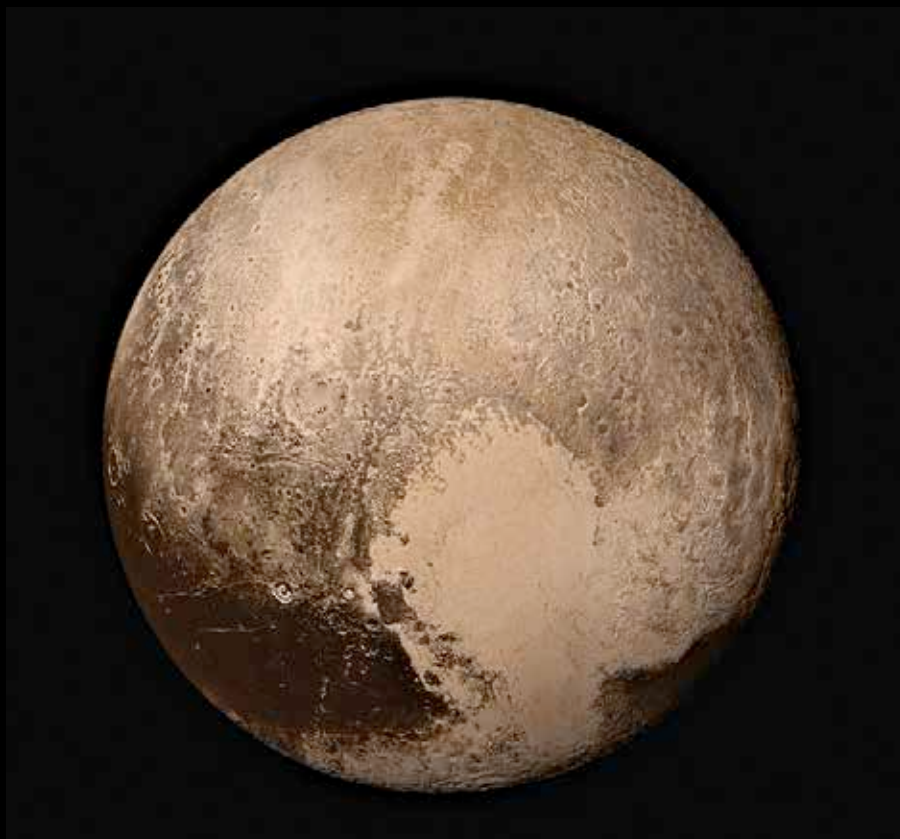
The New Horizons craft was launched in 2006 towards Pluto, and only made its closest approach to the dwarf planet in mid-July 2015. The discoveries it has already made, but which we haven't yet got all the data for, are already mind boggling! And this is just the beginning. The next few months are going to be very exciting indeed.

Pluto

Pluto is (now confirmed as) the largest trans-Neptunian object (that we know of). It has a wildly eccentric orbit around the sun (compared to the planets), and its orbit is at an odd angle to orbital planes of the other planets as well.

It's tiny compared to our planet. In fact, it's a lot smaller than our moon as well, but has a legacy of being called a planet, which allows it to grab our attention and stoke our imaginations.

The first few images and data released by NASA and the New Horizons team are already challenging pre-existing notions we may have had, based on all our observations of Pluto within the orbit of Neptune.



The latest true-colour image of Pluto is breathtaking! Although as of writing, only 5 per cent of the total data that has been collected has reached Earth, we think this image alone is enough of a reason to encourage not just NASA, but also our government to pursue space exploration.

Image Credit: NASA/JHUAPL/SwR



Illustrative image to show the size difference between Earth and Pluto and its moon Charon (Image Credit: NASA)



The image drawn on the moon at the end of the movie Hancock. Does Pluto have a superhero living on it? (Image: Hancock, 2008)